

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | FRIDAY, JULY 24, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Benton report to be released

Ethics commission votes to publish findings from ex-state representative's harassment investigation

By **Jeremy Gerner**
and **Rick Pearson**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The state's Legislative Ethics Commission voted unanimously on Thursday to publish a report outlining an investigation into the conduct of disgraced ex-state Rep. Harry Benton, who resigned earlier this month amid allegations of sexual

harassment, but a state law giving Benton a chance to comment on the report means it likely won't be released until month's end.

The decision by the eight-member commission, composed of four Democratic and four Republican lawmakers, marks the first time the legislative inspector general's office has been authorized to release an investigative report since 2020.

"Concerning the complaint against former Rep. Harry Benton, we voted to publish the report pursuant to our statutory obligations," Republican state Rep. Jeff Keicher of Sycamore, who chairs the commission, said in a prepared statement. "To protect the privacy of those involved in this case, the respondent and complainant will be given the opportunity to review the report for potential redactions, which the



Benton

Commission will review."

Keicher also said that since the commission has voted to publicize the report, the State Officials and Employees Ethics Act requires the parties involved in the complaint, including Benton, to be allowed to review it, offer redaction suggestions and provide a response to be published alongside the report if they wish.

While Keicher did not say exactly when the report would be released,

he said the commission intends to complete this review process by next Friday, July 31.

In a prepared statement, House Republican leader Tony McComb of Savanna thanked the commission for its decision, saying "transparency is key for us to move forward, understand how we can improve, and to demand accountability for those who failed to uphold the integrity of our chamber."

Illinois House Speaker Emanuel

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An image of Patrick Kane is projected on a large curtain as Blackhawks players from the championship years 2010, 2013 and 2015 are honored before a game between the Blackhawks and the Bruins at the United Center in Chicago on Jan. 17. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

The past is present

Kane's return to the Blackhawks is a marketing coup — but will it help them win?



Paul Sullivan
IN THE WAKE OF THE NEWS

When it comes to promoting nostalgia, no one does it quite like the Chicago Blackhawks.

So it's not surprising the Hawks would bring back franchise legend Patrick Kane at 37 to re-create memories of the three-time Stanley Cup champions of the 2010s, pairing him

with the next franchise savior — Connor Bedard — through the 2027-28 season.

Of course, any resemblance between those teams and the current edition of the Hawks is coincidental, and you don't need AI to make a 37-year-old Kane look much different from his 19-year-old self.

Kane signed a two-year deal Thursday with an annual average of \$8 million, which reminds us of his number, 88. It's seen by many as overpaying for a player whose best years are in the past, but considering the marketing aspect for the Hawks, it's probably worth every penny.

Word of the signing spread quickly,

almost as though it was part of a well-planned advertising campaign. A "Welcome Home Patrick Kane!" message appeared on the Wrigley Field marquee, and the Bears tweeted a photo of Kane lifting the Stanley Cup while wearing a Bears jersey at Soldier Field, along with the message, "He's baaaaaack." The Hawks sent out several tweets, including one of Kane skating at the Blackhawks Ice Center, where he has been working out all summer.

Everyone was happy, not the least of whom was general manager Kyle Davidson, who has been adding talent

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HE'S BACK: Patrick Kane, 37, signed a two-year, \$16 million contract with the Blackhawks on Thursday, returning to the team with which the future Hall of Famer spent his first 16 seasons and won three Stanley Cups. **Sports**

Houthis hit Saudi tankers in Red Sea

Barrel of oil cost tops \$100 as attacks may widen US-Iran clash

By **Elena Becatoros**,
Fatma Khaled
and **Collin Binkley**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

CAIRO — Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels said they attacked two Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea on Thursday, potentially widening the Iran war as international oil topped \$100 a barrel.

The Houthis have threatened to shut down another key trade route, with the world economy already reeling from Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Meanwhile, Iran and the U.S. have stepped up their attacks as they vie for control of the strait, through which 20% of the world's oil and gas transited in peacetime, setting off a scramble for alternative routes.

As the U.S. carried out a 12th night of strikes across Iran, President Donald Trump threatened "major military punishment" against the Houthis if their attacks on ships continue.

"If they do this again, the U.S. will hold Iran responsible, in that the Houthis are a Surrogate and/or Proxy of Iran, and major military punishment will be inflicted upon Iran and, of course, the Houthis, themselves," Trump wrote on social media.

As the rhetoric escalated, so did the economic fallout.

The price for a barrel of Brent crude oil, the international standard, jumped 7% Thursday, to settle at \$100.69. That is the highest level since May, before the two sides reached a preliminary peace agreement last month that has since collapsed. Oil had been \$72 early this month.

Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi of Iraq, which has close ties to both the

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INSIDE

Illinois to annually honor Emmett Till

Under a new law Gov. JB Pritzker signed Thursday, Illinois will annually honor Emmett Till, the Black teenager from Chicago whose 1955 murder galvanized the Civil Rights Movement. **Chicagoland**, Page A2

Year where (almost) everyone nominated

With the Goodman Theatre leading the way with 24 nominations, the Joseph Jefferson Awards committee announced a huge slate of 2026 Equity Jeff Award nominees on Wednesday. **Arts & Entertainment**

'For movie people, you can liken this to the Eras tour'



Melissa Quaiyoom checks in at the box office at 2:24 a.m. to watch "The Odyssey" in IMAX 70 mm at Cinemark Seven Bridges and IMAX theater on Thursday in Woodridge. **JAMES C. SVEHLA/FOR THE TRIBUNE**

Woodridge draws thousands from across the country to see 'The Odyssey' in IMAX 70 mm

By **Lila Hempel-Edgers**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

John Marks admits he didn't have to drive his family across state lines in the middle of the night to see "The Odyssey." But as he stood in the lobby of Woodridge's Cinemark Seven Bridges and IMAX at 2 a.m. on Thursday, he couldn't imagine seeing it anywhere else.

The Indiana resident is one of thousands flocking to the multiplex since the film's release last week. One of only 25 theaters nationwide showing "The Odyssey" in IMAX 70 mm, the southwestern suburb has become an unlikely destination for cinephiles

determined to watch the nearly three-hour film as director Christopher Nolan intended.

"For movie people, you can liken this to the Eras tour," said Peter Spedale, 40, a member of the Chicago Indie Critics. "This is the event of the year, and they're going to find the best quality screen that exists on the planet and go there."

Like Taylor Swift's wildly popular concert series, "The Odyssey" has become an event fans are willing to invest in. At some theaters, like AMC Lincoln Square 13 in New York City, individual resale tickets have climbed into the thou-

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